

WATERWATCH · PROBLEM STATEMENT

WaterWatch problem statement

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.2	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Populate to TRL 2 (problem, users, context, constraints, prior work, open questions)
0.1	2026-09-24	Amish Chadha	Initial scaffold

WaterWatch problem statement

Rural water points go untested between rare lab visits, so a chlorinator that runs dry or a storm that clouds the source can go unnoticed for weeks while people keep drinking the water.

■ The problem

In 2024, 2.1 billion people still lacked safely managed drinking water, and about 40 % of rural people had no safely managed service ([WHO and UNICEF JMP, 2025](#); [JMP report 2025](#)). Many rural schemes now chlorinate at the tank or with an in-line doser, but the check that the chlorine actually reaches the tap is a manual test with a comparator kit, done when a technician visits.

Two quantities tell an operator most of what they need to act on:

- **Free chlorine residual.** WHO guidance, as summarized for field use by Oxfam, is at least 0.5 mg/L after 30 min of contact at pH below 8, and at least 0.2 mg/L at the point of delivery ([Oxfam WASH, chlorination in emergencies](#)). No residual at the tap means the dose is missing or used up, and the water has no protection against recontamination.
- **Turbidity.** Particles shield microbes from chlorine. Chlorination loses effectiveness above about 10 NTU and is not recommended above 100 NTU without pre-treatment (same source); WHO's review of turbidity explains why lower is better ([WHO, Water quality and health: review of turbidity](#)).

Remote monitoring has already changed rural water services for **functionality**. Cellular sensors on handpumps in Rwanda shortened repair times when paired with a maintenance service that acted on the data, and similar sensors have tracked functionality and use in Nigeria ([Nagel et al., ES&T 2015](#); [Plateau State sensors, 2022](#); [Thomson, WIRES Water 2021](#)). The same is not yet true for **water quality**. Reagent-free in-line chlorine analyzers are built for utilities: an amperometric probe alone lists at about \$1,900 ([Sensorex FCL](#)) and needs a flow cell, a transmitter and mains power. Low-cost parts exist but are not yet a system: a proven open-source turbidimeter ([Kelley et al., Sensors 2014](#)), research graphite chlorine sensors ([Pan et al., Anal. Chem. 2015](#); [pencil graphite electrodes, PLOS ONE 2021](#)) and early long-term trials of low-cost chlorine sensors in on-site water reuse ([Water Science and Technology, 2025](#)). There is no open, solar-powered reference design that a small operator can build, install on a tapstand and trust enough to act on.

■ Users and context

Table 1. Users and context (proposed; to be confirmed through co-design).

User	Need	Context
Tapstand caretaker or water committee member	A plain alert when the water at the tap needs attention, and a simple monthly check routine	Village tapstand, kiosk or school tank; phone with SMS, often not a smartphone
Scheme operator or maintenance service provider	Chlorine and turbidity trends from many points, so dosing and repairs can be targeted	Small utility, NGO or private operator serving several villages
District water or health officer	Evidence that treated water reaches people, especially during cholera or flood season	Periodic review; outbreak response
Researcher or open hardware community	A reproducible, inspectable design to build on	University labs, makerspaces, WASH research groups

Typical site: a public tapstand or a storage tank outlet on a piped rural scheme with chlorination at the source or tank. No mains power. Ambient temperature from about 0 to 45 °C, direct sun, dust and splashing. Cellular coverage is usually 2G or LTE-M/NB-IoT; some districts have a LoRaWAN gateway.

■ Constraints

- Garage-buildable prototype, about \$300 USD in parts per unit (`project.yaml`), using off-the-shelf modules and simple fabricated parts.
- Solar powered, with no mains connection and no change to the tapstand beyond one tee on the riser.
- Must not waste much treated water, and must not contaminate the supply (backflow and material safety).
- Must be maintainable by a trained caretaker with a comparator kit, without special tools.
- Must not claim that water is "safe". It reports measurements and alerts; accredited lab testing, including microbiological testing, stays necessary.

■ Out of scope

- Microbiological detection (for example *E. coli*); the sensor watches indicators only.
- Chemical contaminants such as arsenic, fluoride or nitrate.
- Controlling the chlorine dose; WaterWatch observes and alerts, it does not dose.
- Household point-of-use treatment.

■ Co-design checklist

- [] Identify a partner scheme operator or maintenance service and two or three pilot sites.
- [] Interview caretakers, operators and district officers on alert content, language, thresholds and who acts.
- [] Confirm local cellular coverage and SMS costs, or LoRaWAN availability.
- [] Agree where flushed sample water goes at each site.
- [] Agree who owns the data and who may see it.

■ Open questions

- Which partner and region first? Proposed, awaiting Amish (see WWT-PRC-001).
- Tapstand only, or also storage tank outlets and kiosks? Proposed: tapstands first, awaiting Amish.

- Which alert thresholds should be defaults? Proposed: free chlorine below 0.2 mg/L and turbidity above 5 NTU, site-adjustable, awaiting Amish and partner input.